

TEA CUSTOMS AROUND THE WORLD

Tea recipes and traditions differ from country to country and region to region, and are shaped by diverse factors, such as geographical location, availability of ingredients, and dietary practices. The following three regions stand out for their unique tea-drinking rituals.

EAST FRISIA, GERMANY

Located on the northern coast of Germany and facing the North Sea, East Frisia's relative isolation has resulted in a unique tea culture.

Tea has been consumed in the region since the drink was introduced to Europe in the 17th century. By the 1800s, the East Frisians were making and preparing their own distinct blend, and the techniques practiced have remained unchanged. Today, the annual per capita consumption of tea in East Frisia is 634 pints (300 liters)—among the highest in the world.

There are four local blenders—Bünting, Onno Behrends, Thiele, and Uwe Rolf—who buy their tea in Hamburg, the largest hub for tea importing in Europe. They carefully guard their recipes, but the strong black blends contain mostly second flush Assam leaves, with small amounts of Ceylon and Darjeeling.

The tea is prepared in a porcelain teapot using generous amounts of dry leaf to create a strong infusion. To serve, lumps of *kluntjes*, a type of rock sugar, are placed in small porcelain cups. The infusion is poured on top and heavy cream is added. The mixture is not stirred—the sugar melts slowly, sweetening subsequent cups, while the cream creates a “tea cloud” and slowly mixes in. Rich and malty in flavor, a fortifying measure of rum is added during the winter months.

TEA CUPS

East Frisian tea is served in small, often ornate, porcelain cups.

